



battled through a calf strain to play in Game 6, managing limited minutes only because of his team's dominant performance. The injury raised ominous questions about his availability for the decisive game.

Game 7 remained competitive through the first half, but disaster struck the Pacers when Haliburton suffered a devastating Achilles tear and had to leave the game. The injury, which typically sidelines NBA players for at least a full season, was particularly cruel given that calf strains often precede Achilles problems.

Playing Haliburton with the injury had been a calculated risk with little alternative. His elite playmaking ability, three-point shooting, and fearless clutch play had been the catalyst for the Pacers exceeding expectations all season. Without him, they had no realistic chance in Game 7.

Guards Andrew Nembhard and McConnell tried valiantly to fill the void, but replacing Haliburton's production proved impossible. The Thunder's defence regained its dominant form in the third quarter, building a lead that exceeded 20 points by the period's end. Despite a spirited fourth-quarter effort, the Pacers couldn't overcome the massive deficit.

The Thunder emerged as



Major blow: Indiana Pacers superstar Tyrese Haliburton could miss the entire 2025-26 NBA season after having surgery on a torn right Achilles tendon. ^{AP}

deserved champions, though fortune played a role in their victory. Whether Haliburton could have led the Pacers to an upset will forever remain one of basketball's great what-ifs, but the Thunder's championship was earned through years of patient building and exceptional execution.

Dynasty in the making

This championship appears to be just the beginning for the Thunder. Their young core remains in their prime, while Presti's shrewd resource management and Mark Daigneault's effective coaching provide a foundation for sustained success.

Presti deserves particular credit for seamlessly transitioning from one championship-calibre core to another. The same executive who drafted Durant, Westbrook, and Harden has now built around SGA, Williams, Holmgren, and their supporting cast.

After 13 years of waiting, the Thunder have returned to the apex. With their combination of talent, depth, and organisational excellence, expect them to remain a championship threat for years to come.



Key Stats from the Thunder's Historic 2024-25 Season

The Thunder became just the fourth team in NBA history to win 84 games in a season (regular season and playoffs combined), joining:

- 2015-16 Golden State Warriors (88-18).
- 1995-96 Chicago Bulls (87-13).
- 1996-97 Chicago Bulls (84-17).

They were the best defensive team in the regular season by a wide margin:

- Allowed 2.5 fewer points per 100 possessions than the second-ranked Orlando Magic
- This is the second-largest gap between the top two defensive teams in any season over the last 29 years (play-by-play era).

Shai Gilgeous-Alexander averaged over 30 points per game across the regular season and playoffs:

- He is just the fourth player to do so for a championship team
- The others: Kareem Abdul-Jabbar (1970-71), Rick Barry (1974-75), Michael Jordan (four times).

Stats credit: NBA